Travel Pace
Scenes Between the Beats

You are an adventurer! What an exciting thing to be. Congratulations! In some other game, we might be embarking on a campaign that spans years of real time, spending days traveling through untold imaginary worlds, and devoting hours to our characters and their arcs, all in service of telling our stories.

We don't have time for any of that. We have an afternoon. Well, we have a few hours really. Can't have this taking all day. Not this weekend, I have other plans, you know? Maybe some other weekend, but we're not in high school anymore, and it's hard to find the time or energy for big twelve-hour sessions like we used to.

So today, let's just play a whole campaign. But combat takes so long, and no one really wants to be the GM, so how about this instead?

Playing the Game!

The goal of Travel Pace is to briefly narrate the action and plot elements of a traditional TTRPG campaign and then roleplay the in-between moments. That narration will set the stage for the actually important part of this game, scenes of character-to-character connection. What we're here for are the instances of character development, moments where characters can share how they think and feel, or the banter by the fireside after a bloody battle. The scenes between the beats of a traditional TTRPG's story: the celebration of a hard-earned victory, or the mourning of a tragic loss.

In this game, every Player takes the role of an Adventurer setting out on a quest. Unlike many other TTRPGs, there is no GM in Travel Pace. Instead, players take turns narrating what events just happened to their Adventurers, setting a scene for the party. Then the group, in character as their respective Adventurer, reacts. They grieve, celebrate, commiserate, plan, argue, apologize, whatever their particular situation calls for. Then, once the conversation has run its course, someone establishes where the party is going to next, and the cycle repeats until the adventuring is complete.

Mechanically, what does this look like?

The Rules

Step 1: Character Creation

Each Player needs to create an Adventurer, which will be the character that they shepherd through the game. Character creation is a simple process: just briefly describe the character. Use maybe 2-3 words. Pick an archetype, a fighting style, a school or magic, an origin, or a singular adjective. Keep it simple, keep it iconic. Something as straightforward as “Dwarven Warrior,” “Elven Archer,” or “Undead Alchemist” is perfect.

Try not to be too specific. The game is about who your character is and how they react to the events around them, not about who they were before the game started. “Devious Flamecaster” would be a great character to play! But “Flame sorcerer in a secret cult who worships the undead goddess of trickery and lies” is too much. Maybe we can learn that your Devious Flamecaster is in that trickery cult as the story unfolds, but coming into the game with too many preconceived ideas of who your character is will make you less flexible during roleplay. Travel Pace is a game of seeing where things go, not planning your whole course in advance.

My advice? Pick a way the character would be useful in an adventuring party (healer, warrior, alchemist, archer, alchemist, druid, ice mage, face puncher, berserker, smooth talker) and pick one or two descriptors (human, dwarven, undead, elven, draconic, devious, speedy, large, law abiding, “law abiding,” vampiric). That should be enough to get you started, and you can let the character and their story develop as you play.

All you need now is a name, pronouns, and your character’s physical description.

Step 2: The Gameplay Loop

Once everyone has made their characters, determine the order of who will set up scenes. This can be done by consensus, by rolling a die and going from highest to lowest, or some combination. You can decide what works best based on your group. Going first or last might be particularly exciting or daunting for people.

The first player narrates how and why the adventuring party has come together. Give some details about the world, but don’t take too long: Travel Pace is a game about sharing the spotlight, not stealing it.
(Examples of play are included in *italics* throughout).

Player 1, Narration: The small village of Ashendale was cold and rainy on the day that the gnolls attacked. The Bolvar farmstead burned in the distance, and the screams of the villagers echoed through the night as the beasts charged up the road into town. But

five Adventurers made their stand there at the edge of Ashendale and saved the small community from destruction.

The first player tells the group where the Adventurers have found a moment of respite. It's within this moment of peace that the Players get their first chance to roleplay their characters!

Player 1, Narration: Once the beasts were defeated and the villagers calmed, the five Adventurers were able to breathe and relax. They found themselves sitting at a table in the Ashendale inn, free mugs of ale in front of them as meager thanks for their good deeds.
Player 1 (Owen, the half-orc stabbomancer): "So… That was awkward."
Player 2 (Themetriana, the renowned orator): "Shut up, you almost got me killed!"
Player 3 (Felix, the big puncher): "He already apologized, get over it."

At some point during this scene the first Player establishes where the party needs to go next, and the scene ends when it comes to a natural conclusion.

Player 1 (Owen): Thank you for accepting my apology. If we're going to try to find the gnolls village together, we should at least be on good terms."

When the scene ends, the second Player narrates what happens following this event, and then sets up another scene in a calm moment once the action has wound down.

Player 2, Narration: With some vague directions from the locals, a couple days of travel north brought our Adventurers to the village of the gnolls. The mayor of the gnoll village, Craftpaw the Unbloodied, was happy to talk to the party. The village had also fallen victim to gnoll raids, you see, and Craftpaw explained that the wizard who lives at the top of the tallest peak in the nearby Snowcloaked Range was mind controlling the mountain gnolls. That evening, the party went for dinner at a restaurant in town to rest and to plan.
Player 2 (Themetriana): "Can we trust Mayor Craftpaw?"
Player 1 (Owen) "Absolutely!"
Player 4 (Rowena, the gnome phasmalist): "Absolutely not!"

As before, the Player who set the scene originally sets up where the party is heading next.
Player 2 (Themetriana): "So, it's decided. We'll investigate the wizard's tower."

This pattern continues, with the third Player setting a scene and establishing the next destination *(Player 3 (as Felix): "So we have to find the person mind controlling the wizard!")*, and then the fourth (*Player 4 (as Rowena): "At the bottom of that dungeon is the beast that has caused all of this chaos.")* and so on until the last player takes their turn. Instead of setting a scene, the last Player has the honor of narrating the final confrontation.

Player 5, Narration: The fight through the dungeon was arduous. Long, bloody hours were spent trekking through, but ultimately the Adventurers made it to the cavern of the Telestrade. It threatened, cajoled, bribed, and begged, and when our heroes showed a moment's hesitation it struck. But that would ultimately seal its fate, as all doubt was removed from the Adventurers' minds. They fought with all the ferocity they had left, and were victorious.

The game is ending, and now all that is left is for each Player to give their Adventurer an epilogue. Go in reverse order, Player 5, then Player 4, and so on. If anyone has a suggestion for someone else's ending, they can bring those suggestions forward respectfully, but the final decisions for each Adventurer are in the hands of their Player.

Player 5: "Gurkle, the half drunken hierophant, retired after that. They said nothing would live up to the excitement. If Owen ends up opening that tavern he mentioned, Gurkle would become a regular."
Player 1: "Naturally! Owen would absolutely save Gurkle a spot at the bar. Reserved seating, so they can shoot the shit."
Player 4: "Rowena would wander the land, looking for more adventure. There are always more people who need help."
Player 3: "I think Rowena and Felix kinda had a thing, would she let Felix tag along?"
Player 4 (as Rowena): "Felix, I thought I'd be waiting for you forever. Never do that to me again."
Player 3 (as Felix): "I would never dream of disappointing you."
Player 2: "Themetriana died in the battle with the Telestrade."
Player 1: "Tragic! Was it heroic at least?"
Player 2: "Incredibly. She was probably trying to save Owen when he got himself in trouble."
Player 1: "That tracks. Can Owen plan her funeral?"
Player 2: "... I think Rowena would be better suited to that."
Player 4 (as Rowena): "It's what Themetriana would have wanted, Owen, but you can help pick out flowers."

The epilogue is the last chance to tell these Adventurers' stories, to wrap things up. Once everyone is satisfied with their character's ending, that's it. Game over. I hope you had fun, let's play again soon!

Suggestions, Starters, and Adjectives

Sometimes it's not super easy to come up with what happens next, who your character should be, or how to get the game started. Happens to the best of us, no worries! Here is a collection of some things you may find useful to get the creative juices flowing.

How to get the Roleplay flowing- The fun of the game comes entirely from Players wanting to explore the characters they and their friends have created. When the roleplay is good, it comes easily and naturally to everyone. But it can be difficult to get started sometimes, especially if Players are new to roleplaying or are getting used to their characters.

Suggestion #1- Offer your opinion, in character, on whatever just happened. Saying something as simple as *"I think that guy was sketchy and we shouldn't trust what he told us,"* will prompt others to keep talking. Do the other characters agree? Disagree? Do we even have the luxury of being skeptical?? Now the roleplay is flowing.

Suggestion #2- Ask a question, and give someone else a chance to create a detail about the game by answering. Pick a question that can establish the group's goal or next step towards a goal, and then support whatever answer you get. Or, pick a question that lets the group offer an opinion which can create back and forth between characters (this variant is similar to suggestion #1, just a different angle on it).

Player 1: "That guy was useless, why did we even come here?"

Player 2: "It wasn't totally useless, we got a clue. Besides, we have to find out where Captain Jaklebeard sailed off to before he's too far gone to chase.

Player 1: "I guess we have a clue now, but I have no clue how to interpret it."

Player 3: "Obviously it means we have to sail to the Cape of Dreaded Seaclaws. Were you not paying attention?"

Character Creation Suggestions: Below are some suggestions for descriptors and roles to help you decide who your character is. Pick one or two descriptors from the first list and a role from the second, and you're set. Or just peruse the lists and take some inspiration. Remember that your initial description of your character is simply a place to start, something to guide roleplaying decisions until you figure out who this character is. If I say my character is a Devout Farmer, and after the first scene neither of those things come up again, that's okay as long as I had fun roleplaying whoever my character ended up being.

Descriptors- Lowly, Ace, Elven, Dwarven, Dragonforged, Holy, Educated,

Heroic, Well-Traveled, Haunted, Undead, Subterranean, Horned, Savvy, Untrained, Expert, Scatterbrained, Caffeinated, Unknown.

Roles- Archer, Fighter, Hemomancer, Savant, Chef, Artisan, Paladin, Clerk, Cleric, Bard, Oracle, Witch, Truthseeker, Cryomancer, Sparkthrower, Wrestler, Scout, Farmer, Soldier, Spy.

Campaign Scenarios- Setting the stage for the game is incredibly important, and can be a daunting task. Included here are a few prompts for starting scenarios that you can use instead of creating one of your own. Feel free to choose one to use, or roll a d4 to decide randomly. Read or paraphrase the prompt to the other Players, or use it as inspiration and make something new. My general tip for starting the game is to put the Adventurers together to defeat an immediate threat and decide during the roleplay what to do about it, or put them in an unfamiliar setting and decide during the roleplay what brought them here. There are millions of different frameworks, but these two are the most straightforward. If you think the other players are strong improvisers, it could be fun to give them very few details at all, though that is an advanced maneuver.

[1- Ashendale] The small village of Ashendale was cold and rainy on the day that the gnolls attacked. The Bolvar farmstead was burning in the distance, and the villagers were screaming as the beasts charged up the road into town. But several Adventurers made their stand there at the edge of town and were victorious.

Once the beasts were defeated and the villagers were calmed, those five Adventurers were able to breathe and relax. They found themselves sitting at a table in the local inn, with free mugs of ale in front of them as meager thanks for their good deeds.

[2- The Jungle of the Divine] A hundred years ago, a flourishing city stood in the heart of the Jungle of the Divine. Those who fled the city during its fall have said that it had been beautiful—a true triumph over the nearly inhospitable jungle it was inexplicably built in. But even those that lived there at the end didn't know how it thrived, how the city was able to support the massive population it supposedly did when the jungles are haunted by marauding beasts, monsters, and bandits making resupply difficult.

Upon arriving at the ruins of the city, battered and bruised from the journey, a group of Adventurers found a moment to rest in what used to be a square or perhaps a small market.

[3- Across the Rolling Tundra] The snowy tundras of the Graton Wastes were supposed to be empty, though that had never stopped the rich and delusional from sending Adventurers into it to search for anything of value. The occasional successful expedition that returned with loads of treasure from ancient ruins only fueled those delusions.

When this group of Adventurers was commissioned for this expedition, the

promise of treasure was great. This lead was supposed to be a sure thing! The treasure map was legible, though quite old, and seemed legit.

The trip took longer than the Adventurers were promised, but finally, as the group settled into their camp for the evening and the almost omnipresent snow cleared from the area, they caught their first glimpse of the promised ruins across the rolling tundra.

[4- On the Warpath] When the Pinlok Army came looking for conscripts to fight the ever present war in the west, no excuse was good enough. The first time they came, they took volunteers. The next time, most healthy adults whether they wanted to go or not. After that, they took slightly older recruits, or later anyone with a “non essential” job. Until, after so many iterations, it’s almost surprising that they left anyone behind at all.

This war of aggression had been going on for generations, and the emperor seemed intent on throwing everyone into the meat grinder to finally end it. But, for those who didn’t want to fight in this war, where was there to go? The most obvious solution was to run, but as our Adventurers settled into their hidden camp for the night, one question loomed. They could run, but where could they possibly hide?

On Sharing, Adding On, and Remixing

I hope anyone who plays Travel Pace has a good time. It’s an idea that has been marinating in my brain for the better part of a year, at least. But at the same time, I know that my idea of a great game won’t be the right game for everyone, or for every get-together. To remedy that, I encourage anyone who has played the game to make additions or edits to make the game right for themselves.

Travel Pace is openly licensed under the Creative Commons Attribution-Sharealike license. That means anyone can do almost whatever they want with this game, as long as I am attributed as the creator and anything you make from this work is shared with the same license. Feel free to share it, change it, add to it, subtract from it, even sell your own derivative works made from it. Further, I encourage every player to use it, break it, fix it, trash it, change it, mail upgrade it, charge it, point it, zoom it, press it, snap it, work it, etc. Technologic.

This game is written as a fantasy game, but it can easily do sci fi or any other genre as long as the players all come into it with the right expectations. I would like to write some supplemental material for other genres, though that is beyond the scope of this release.

At time of writing, version 0.6.1 is a mostly complete vision of the game. The rules may change slightly through playtesting, and I intend to add more Campaign Scenarios, as well as suggestions for plot beats and endings. Adding these things would also be a great way to add on and remix the game, which I continue to encourage

all players to do.

For now, this is it. This is the game. I hope you, dear reader, enjoy playing it. It's important to me. But even if you don't enjoy it, that's okay. No hard feelings, I'm just glad you took the time to at least read the rules. I hope Travel Pace can give anyone who experiences the game hours of enjoyment, or at least a couple of good ideas for their next creative endeavor.

Thank you so much for playing my game. I'll see ya around.